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Head, Not Tail: Joy, Memory, and the Light That Increases on 15 Elul

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The Daily Learning Portions

- **Chumash:** Parshat Ki Tavo, 6th aliyah — Devarim 28:7–28:69
- **Tehillim:** Chapters 77–78 (Elul extra chapters: 43–45 per Hayom Yom / Baal Shem Tov custom)
- **Tanya:** Iggeret HaKodesh, beginning of Epistle 14
- **Rambam (3 ch.):** Hilchot Parah Adumah 14–15; Hilchot Tum'at Tzara'at 1
- **Sefer HaMitzvot:** Positive Commandment 108 — *mei niddah* (completing the red-heifer cycle as the code turns to *tzara'at*)
- **Hayom Yom:** Elul 15 — Founding of Tomchei Temimim; beginning of study on Chai Elul; the name *temimim*

Seasonal frame. Elul is the month of the King in the Field: accessible, smiling, receiving whoever comes. Shofar is sounded daily. Tefillin and mezuzot are checked. Three extra chapters of Tehillim are recited each day from 1 Elul through Yom Kippur. Today is Erev Shabbat of Ki Tavo — the sixth aliyah that carries the nation from open-treasury blessing to the long *tochacha*, names the missing joy that turns abundance into exile, and seals "the words of the covenant… besides the covenant which He made with them at Horeb" (28:69). Three days remain until Chai Elul. Fourteen days remain until Erev Rosh Hashanah.

I. The Sixth Aliyah: Blessing That Commands, Curse That Overtakes, and the Joy That Was Withheld

The fifth aliyah ended with blessings that "come upon you and overtake you" (28:2) and with the quiet line: blessed when you come and blessed when you depart (28:6). The sixth does not change the covenant. It specifies it.

First the blessings become national and visible:

> *"The Lord will cause your enemies who rise against you to be struck down before you; they will come out against you in one way and flee before you in seven ways. The Lord will command the blessing upon you in your storehouses and in all that you set your hand to… The Lord will establish you as a holy people to Himself… And all the peoples of the earth shall see that the Name of the Lord is called upon you, and they shall fear you… The Lord will open to you His good treasury, the heavens, to give the rain of your land in its season… And the Lord will make you the head and not the tail, and you shall be only above and not beneath — if you hearken to the commandments of the Lord your G-d…" (28:7–13)*

Rashi on the seven-way flight: panic scatters what marched as one. On the open treasury: rain in its time is not a meteorological courtesy; it is commanded blessing. “Head and not tail” is not license to dominate. It is prominence under the Name that the nations see called upon Israel. The condition is repeated and sharpened: walk in His ways; do not turn aside right or left (28:14).

Then the text turns on the same hinge used for blessing:

> *“But it shall come to pass, if you will not hearken to the voice of the Lord your G-d… that all these curses shall come upon you and overtake you.” (28:15)*

What follows (28:16–68) is the long *tochacha* of Ki Tavo: city and field, basket and kneading-bowl, drought that is copper sky and iron earth, disease, defeat, siege, exile, a life hung in doubt, a return to Egypt in ships with no buyer. Moses speaks it in the singular. Rashi notes that these curses are, in places, milder in form than Vayikra 26 and yet more intimate: they pursue the person who thought the covenant was only public ritual.

The diagnostic verse sits inside the siege:

> *“Because you did not serve the Lord your G-d with joy and with gladness of heart, from the abundance of all things.” (28:47)*

Not because there was no service. Because there was service without *simchah*. Abundance that does not become glad obedience becomes the very material of exile. The Midrash and later *meforshim* hear here both a historical warning and an inner law: a mitzvah performed as burden, even if technically complete, has already begun to loosen the bond. The Alter Rebbe’s Elul teaching that the King is in the field does not cancel this verse. It explains it. The King who walks out to meet his people is asking for a face, not a ledger.

The portion closes: “These are the words of the covenant which the Lord commanded Moses to make with the children of Israel in the land of Moab, besides the covenant which He made with them at Horeb” (28:69). Horeb bound them. Moab binds them again, on the threshold of the Land, with blessing and curse that *overtake*. Covenant is not a single signature. It is a renewed consent under clearer light.

Elul reading. Two overtakings stand on the same road. Blessing pursues the one who hearkens. Curse pursues the one who will not. *Bechirah* is not the power to invent a third road. It is the power to turn so that one pursuit, not the other, is allowed to catch you. “Head and not tail” in Elul is first an inner office: do not let the tail of habit wag the year. Serve one commandment this Erev Shabbat with actual joy — not as decoration, as the missing clause of 28:47.

The King is in the field. The field is where storehouses stand and where drought begins. He receives whoever comes. He does not pretend that joy is optional.

II. Tehillim 77–78: Memory That Turns the Night, and Chinuch That Refuses to Forget

The fifteenth of the month reads Asaph in two movements.

Psalm 77 begins in the night: the voice to G-d is not answered; the soul refuses comfort; "Has His kindness ceased forever? Has His promise failed for all generations?" (77:9). Then the psalmist does the Elul work:

> *"I will remember the deeds of the Lord; yes, I will remember Your wonders of old. I will meditate on all Your work, and speak of Your deeds." (77:12–13)*

The turning is not argument. It is *zikaron*. The path of G-d is in the sanctuary; He redeemed Jacob and Joseph with an arm; His way was in the sea, His path in the mighty waters, and His footsteps were not known (77:20). Elul *cheshbon* often starts exactly where Asaph starts — with the fear that this year's evidence does not match last year's kindness. The psalm does not scold the question. It relocates it: remember, meditate, speak. The sea still opened. The footprints remain unseen. Faith here is not blindness. It is disciplined memory under hester.

Psalm 78 is the long *maskil*: "Give ear, my people, to my teaching… I will open my mouth in a parable… which we have heard and known, and our fathers have told us. We will not hide them from their children" (78:1–4). The purpose is named: that the next generation might set its hope in G-d, not forget His works, and keep His commandments (78:7). The counter-history is also named: Ephraim, armed and carrying bows, turned back in the day of battle; they did not keep the covenant; they forgot His wonders (78:9–11). The psalm then recites Exodus and wilderness — water from the rock, manna, complaint, mercy that does not end when anger is just.

Elul and chinuch. Psalm 77 is the father's night. Psalm 78 is the father's table. Erev Shabbat of Ki Tavo is built for this pairing. The *tochacha* is not read to children as terror. It is framed by Asaph: tell the wonders so the children do not become Ephraim-with-a-bow who forgets why the bow was given. The extra Elul chapters today (43–45) keep the same register — thirst for G-d, claiming the people as His, and the King who loves righteousness.

One usable line for the table: "We will not hide them from their children." Hide nothing that is a wonder. Hide nothing that is a warning. The covenant that overtook us is the same covenant we hand across the candles.

III. Tanya — Beginning of Iggeret HaKodesh, Epistle 14: Arouse the Old Love; Increase with the Year

The Alter Rebbe writes to awaken "the old love and fondness for the Holy Land, so that it burn like fiery flames from the inwardness of man and from the depths of his heart, as if this very day the Lord had set His spirit upon us — a spirit of generosity." The people are to consecrate themselves "with a full and generous hand, with one increase after another, from year to year, continually rising," according to the measure of *kodesh ha-elyon*, supreme *chochmah*, which radiates to the Land and is constantly renewed and increased.

The verse he reads is Devarim 11:12: "The eyes of the Lord your G-d are always upon it, from the beginning of the year to the end of the year." Why "to the end of the year," when the next year begins at that very edge? Because each year the light withdraws toward its source — *reishit* written defectively, without an *aleph*, hinting at the covering of the moon on the night of Rosh Hashanah — and through shofar and prayer a *new*, more sublime light is drawn down from *chochmah*, a light that has not shone in this way since the beginning of the world. "The Lord by wisdom founded the earth" (Mishlei 3:19): both the higher land (*malchut* of Atzilut) and the

terrestrial Holy Land receive this annually renewed efflux. Therefore tzedakah for the Land must increase each year in quantity and in vitality. Mortal increase answers Divine increase. The concealment of erev Rosh Hashanah is not absence. It is the pause in which a higher light can be asked for.

Elul reading. We are fifteen days into the month whose end is that withdrawal and that new light. Today's Tanya is not a fundraising letter only. It is a map of the season: old love grows cold; it must be aroused *as if this very day*; giving must rise with the year; the shofar we sound each morning is already practice for the shofar that draws the new *mochin*. The Land is not a slogan. It is the place upon which the eyes rest from beginning to end. Increasing tzedakah is how a person agrees to live inside that gaze.

The King in the Field is the same King whose eyes are on the Land. Accessibility in Elul does not replace the New Year's renewal. It prepares the hand that will give and the mouth that will sound.

IV. Rambam: The Last Waters of the Heifer, and the First Inspection of the Blemish

The three-chapter cycle completes Hilchot Parah Adumah (chapters 14–15) and opens Hilchot Tum'at Tzara'at (chapter 1).

The red-heifer waters are the Torah's most exacting paradox: they purify the one defiled by death and can defile the one who handles them. The closing chapters of the *halachah* concern the limits of that water — what invalidates it after it has been mixed, how sprinkling is done, what remains of the mitzvah when the vessel or the person fails. The learning of 14 Elul already named the cost to the carrier. Today the code finishes the rite and turns.

Tzara'at of the skin, as Rambam opens it, is not a medical chapter. It is a chapter of signs, isolation, and a kohen's seeing. Three signs of impurity on the flesh: white hair, healthy flesh in the midst of the blemish, and spreading. If the signs are present, the kohen declares. If they are not, there is *hefger* — a week of holding, then another looking. Chazal bind *tzara'at* to hidden speech, to slander, to the closed eye that will not see another's dignity. The opening of this *hilchah* on Erev Shabbat of the *tochacha* is not an accident of the cycle. The long curse-list of chapter 28 includes diseases of skin and bewilderment of heart. The Torah answers both with inspection, not with panic: a trained eye, a set time, a possible return to the camp.

Elul reading. *Teshuvah* has the same grammar. Some stains are immediately declared. Some require seven days of honest holding before the next looking. The King in the Field does not skip the kohen's work. He makes the looking possible because He has walked out. Isolation in Elul is not exile. It is the room in which a person lets the blemish be seen.

V. Hayom Yom, 15 Elul: Temimim — Whole Students for a Whole Torah

The Hayom Yom for this date is history that became a standard:

The founding of Yeshivat Tomchei Temimim was on Sunday, 15 Elul 5657 (1897). Study in *nigleh* and in *Divrei Elokim Chayim* began on Wednesday, Chai Elul 5657. On the night of Simchat Torah 5659, after *hakafot*, the Rebbe Rashab proclaimed: the name of the yeshivah is Tomchei Temimim, and the students who study and conduct themselves in its spirit are called *temimim*.

Tamim is whole — not naïve, not untested. The innovation was not a new subject list. It was a refusal to split the student: revealed Torah without the inner Torah, or inner Torah without the discipline of *halachah*. Three days from now the yeshivah's study actually began, on the birthday of the two great lights, the Baal Shem Tov and the Alter Rebbe. Today is the founding. Founding is a decision about what kind of human being the covenant needs.

Elul reading. The sixth aliyah demands a people that can hear blessing and curse without splitting. Psalm 78 demands a generation that is told both the wonders and the failures. Tanya demands an old love that increases rather than coasts. Tomchei Temimim is the institutional form of that demand: do not become a tail of one half of Torah. Be whole. The King in the Field is not looking for specialists in regret. He is looking for *temimim* — people whose study and whose conduct are one spirit.

For a family on Erev Shabbat: one line of *nigleh* and one line of inner teaching at the same table is already the founding in miniature.

VI. Approaches, Synthesis, and the Covenantal Register

Traditional readings of this aliyah divide, usefully, along three lines.

1. **Historical-covenantal.** Ramban and others read the *tochacha* as the map of exile that later generations recognized in their own bones. Moab's covenant is added to Horeb's because the Land is about to be entered; law that will govern soil and kingship must be sworn where the soil can be seen.
2. **Moral-inner.** The Seforno, the Alshich, and Chassidic readings hear 28:47 as the key: joyless service is already a form of departure. The Alter Rebbe's Elul *mashal* of the King in the Field supplies the season in which joy can be recovered without waiting for the palace protocol of Tishrei.
3. **Chinuch-transmission.** Psalm 78 and the founding of Tomchei Temimim insist that the covenant fails when it is not taught whole. Ephraim had weapons and forgot the works. A yeshivah that joins *nigleh* and *Chassidus* is a structural answer to that forgetting.

Synthesis for 15 Elul. Blessing and curse overtake; they are not trophies and not theatrical. Joy is the inner consent that keeps abundance from becoming exile. Memory is the discipline that keeps night from becoming atheism. Increase — of tzedakah, of light, of love for the Land — is how a year agrees to be new. Wholeness of study is how a person refuses to be a tail.

Covenantal-republican resonance (text-supported only). "Head and not tail" under a Name the nations can see is limited prominence, not domination. A people that answers for joyless service is a people whose power is accountable to a law higher than success. Pettit's language of non-domination is a secular analogue, not a source: Torah already forbids the secret injury, the unmarked power, the tail that wags the office. Eric Nelson's "Hebrew Republic" notes that early-modern readers found in Deuteronomy a constitution of limited office. Today's aliyah adds the

missing affect: a republic of the covenant cannot run on compliance alone. It requires the gladness that 28:47 says we failed to give. Tzedakah that increases yearly, as Tanya demands, is one practice of non-domination: the hand opens before the year hardens.

None of this replaces the *peshat*. It follows it.

VII. Practical Avodah and Family Chinuch — Erev Shabbat, 15 Elul

One avodah for the day. Choose one mitzvah already planned for Shabbat — a blessing, a meal, a word to a child, a coin — and do it with actual *simchah*, not as a task cleared before candle lighting. Name the joy. 28:47 is repaired in deed, not in mood.

Four short table points.

1. Blessings overtake and curses overtake. Elul is the hour you stop running from the good.
2. "Head and not tail" begins at home: who sets the tone of the meal?
3. Asaph: we will not hide the wonders from the children. Tell one Exodus-sized kindness from 5786.
4. Fifteen Elul: the yeshivah that refused to split Torah was founded today. One revealed line and one inner line before *kiddush*.

Seasonal acts still in force. Shofar before or after the day's learning. Check tefillin and mezuzot if it has not been done this Elul. Increase tzedakah for the Land by one measurable unit — Tanya's "from year to year." Light candles on time. The King is in the field until the palace gates of Tishrei. Walk out to meet Him before Shabbat takes you in.

Extended Bibliography

Daily portions and text

- Deuteronomy 28:7–69, with Rashi. Sefaria · Chabad, daily Chumash
- Psalms 77–78. Sefaria · Chabad Tehillim
- Tanya, Iggeret HaKodesh, Epistle 14. Chabad · Lessons in Tanya
- Rambam, Hilchot Parah Adumah 14–15; Hilchot Tum'at Tzara'at 1. Chabad Mishneh Torah
- Sefer HaMitzvot, Positive 108. Chabad
- Hayom Yom, Elul 15. Chabad · Tackling Life's Tasks
- Daily calendar, 15 Elul 5786. Chabad

Classical meforshim and Chassidus

- Rashi, Ramban, Seforno, Alshich on Devarim 28.
- Sotah 32a (choreography of Gerizim and Ebal, background to the covenant scene).
- Rabbi Schneur Zalman of Liadi, Likkutei Torah, Ki Tavo; Elul discourses on *Ani le-dodi ve-dodi li* and the King in the Field.
- Rabbi Schneur Zalman of Liadi, Iggeret HaTeshuvah.
- Rabbi Yosef Yitzchak Schneersohn and the Rebbe Rashab on Tomchei Temimim (*Kol ha-yotzei le-milchemet Beit David*).
- Rambam, Hilchot Teshuvah. Sefaria

Elul and High Holiday foundations

- "The King in the Field." Chabad
- Elul customs: daily shofar; extra Tehillim of the Baal Shem Tov; checking tefillin and mezuzot.
- Devarim 11:12 — "from the beginning of the year to the end of the year," as read in Iggeret HaKodesh 14.

Covenantal and republican thought (text-supported parallels only)

- Philip Pettit, *Republicanism: A Theory of Freedom and Government* (Oxford, 1997) — non-domination as freedom from arbitrary power; analogue, not source.
- Eric Nelson, *The Hebrew Republic* (Harvard, 2010) — early-modern readings of biblical limited kingship.
- Deuteronomy's constitutional sequence from Shoftim through Ki Tavo: judges, king under Torah, a people that hears both blessing and curse, and a prominence that is "head and not tail" only if it hearkens.

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